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Reflection Paper #2

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Twigs Naturals

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Internship Reflection Paper

Second 50 Hours

The second 50 hours in my cybersecurity internship with Twigs Naturals have helped me better understand how GRC activities support the broader cybersecurity stance of a company. While my first 50 hours mainly focused on monitoring training completion and policy acknowledgments by each employee and intern, and helping with documentation tasks, my responsibilities during this phase have expanded to focus on security planning and operational improvements. Within each of my most recent projects, I have begun to realize how governance frameworks involve practical processes that help a company manage access controls, maintain compliance, and decrease risk in their technological systems.

One of the earlier projects I have worked on during this phase included developing an Access Control Matrix (in a spreadsheet) that is used to map employee/intern roles to systems that are required for their work. This will assist the core team and the departmental leads in completing their onboarding and offboarding processes more seamlessly (by giving them an idea

of which systems will need access granted to each new employee/intern, and at what level of permission). Ultimately, my supervisor also wanted an inventory of all company applications (also in a spreadsheet, within the same workbook file) to document which systems are used, and what their purpose, data sensitivity, department, and authentication methods are. This helped me understand concepts such as role-based access control and the principle of least privilege.

Another project focused on resolving an issue related to the creation of spam accounts on the company's WordPress website. Of course, making changes to account registration and selectively deleting some accounts involves risk, so my supervisor required a method of procedure (MOP) document to be drafted, where I proposed a few potential options to mitigate this and avoid disrupting legitimate users. Luckily, my primary solution was successful, which involved adjusting account settings in a plugin called *WooCommerce*, where I disabled account creation from the login page (which formerly included both register & login options). Under this new implementation, only legitimate customers may now create an account (which can now only occur during checkout, specifically). This was also a convenient solution, as I was aiming to eliminate this attack surface without new plugins or other more complex solutions. As part of the agreement from the MOP proposal, I validated the new controls to ensure that the checkout, registration, and login functionalities worked as intended. This helped me understand how sometimes even small configuration changes can improve security and operational stability.

I've also continued to support compliance efforts through the eFense vCISO Portal (the company's security platform). This has involved monitoring user training completion, policy acknowledgments, and communicating with individuals who have not completed either of these sets of tasks. Another task of mine related to this that is still ongoing is helping maintain a new selection of standard operating procedures (SOPs) that will need to be uploaded once they have

been properly reviewed and signed. These responsibilities have reinforced the importance of documentation accuracy and user accountability, by ensuring that all employees and interns are aware of policies, and that they formally acknowledge that they understand and follow them.

As I continue this internship as a Cybersecurity Technician Intern, I have begun to reflect more on how GRC work fits within the broader cybersecurity field. I think it's fair to say that a considerable amount of cybersecurity discussions focuses on technical tools and defenses, but this experience at Twigs Naturals has shown how access management, policies, and other documentation are essential in ensuring the secure usage of technology in an organization. I have also realized that I bring strengths in organization, attention to detail, and communication, which I want to focus on maintaining and refining as I continue to coordinate security processes across different teams. Overall, the second 50 hours of my internship have improved my understanding of how cybersecurity works in a business environment, and I'm looking forward to building more technical knowledge and making the most of professional experience opportunities in the third 50 hours of my internship.